



OREGON YOUTH AUTHORITY

Policy Statement

Part II – Youth Services (Facilities)



Subject:

Youth Recreational Activities

Section – Policy Number:

E: Programming – 2.1

Supersedes:

II-E-2.1 (01/12)
II-B-3.1 (11/02)

Effective Date:

06/22/2026

Date of Last

Review/Revision:

None

Related Standards and References:

- [OAR Chapter 416, Division 470](#) (Youth in Custody Prohibited Behaviors and Processing Behavior Violations)
- [OAR Chapter 416, Division 490](#) (Use of Time-out, Room-lock Other, Isolation, Safety Programs, Physical Intervention, and Restraint in OYA Facilities)
- Performance-based Standards (PbS), *Juvenile Correction and Detention Facilities*; Programming
- American Correctional Association, *Standards for Juvenile Correctional Facilities*; 5-JCF-1C-07 (Outdoor Recreational Space); 5-JCF-6G-02 (Recreation Staffing); 5-JCF-6G-03 (Large Muscle Activity and Leisure Recreation); 5-JCF-6G-04 (Recreation Schedules); 5-JCF-6G-05 (Indoor and Outdoor Activities)
- [OYA policy](#): II-B-1.2 Use of Time-out, Special Program Placement, Isolation
II-F-1.0 Youth Rights - Facilities
- OYA form: YA 4412 Recreation Intake Assessment
- [OSAA Heat Index calculator](#)

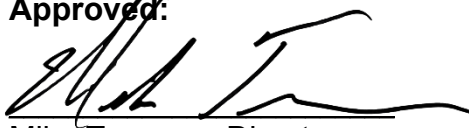
Related Procedures:

- [FAC II-E-2.1](#) Youth OSAA Participation in OYA Facilities

Policy Owner:

Facility Services Assistant Director

Approved:


Mike Tessean, Director

I. PURPOSE:

This policy directs OYA facility staff in providing structured recreational activities for OYA youth in OYA facilities.

II. POLICY DEFINITIONS:

Horseplay: Acting in a seemingly playful way that distracts from the order and potential safety of the unit or facility operations.

Large Muscle Exercise: Planned, structured, and repetitive bodily movement that improves circulation and cardiovascular health by moving the large muscle groups of the body. Examples include walking, jogging, swimming, basketball, and other physical activities.

Recreational activities: Activities which foster the health and social well-being of individuals through constructive use of free time to keep physically fit, mentally alert, and emotionally balanced. Recreational activities foster creativity, bring pleasure and amusement, and a sense of accomplishment to individuals.

III. POLICY:

OYA recognizes exercise and recreation as essential to good health. Opportunities for play and creative activity are necessary for healthy development. Recreational programs in OYA facilities provide youth opportunities to practice social skills; alleviate idleness and boredom; positive reinforcement; develop the concepts of cooperation and sportsmanship; and improve self-esteem, health and physical conditioning.

IV. GENERAL STANDARDS:

A. Each OYA facility must offer recreation programs to youth as soon as the youth are admitted into the facility.

1. At a minimum, each facility must provide for one hour of large muscle exercise each weekday, and two hours each day on weekends.

To meet this standard, facilities may take advantage of education system courses offered as part of the physical education curriculum.

2. Equal opportunities to participate in recreational activities must be provided to all youth with the following exceptions:
 - a) Youth in isolation must be allowed daily opportunity for large muscle exercise outside or in a gym. Youth may not be restricted from this activity unless they pose a danger to themselves or others in accordance with OYA policy II-B-1.2 Use of Time-out, Room-lock Other, Isolation, and Safety Program.
 - b) In cases where the number of participants in a specific activity is limited, staff will ensure youth take turns participating or will offer alternative activities if time does not permit all youth to participate in the activity.
 - c) Facility administration must offer a youth who is physically limited due to a medical condition appropriate alternative activities that meet the youth's recreational needs as determined by Health Services staff.
 - d) Staff may temporarily suspend a youth who demonstrates unacceptable behavior during an activity from the activity in order to maintain safety for all participants.

- e) Staff must assist youth who have medical or mental health conditions that curtail their participation or who may need modifications in order to participate.
- 3. At no time will physical activity be used as a sanction or accountability option.
- 4. At no time will denying physical activity be used as a sanction or accountability option.

B. Recreation Program Structure

- 1. Staff designated by the facility superintendent must complete a form YA 4412 Recreation Intake Assessment within 30 days of a youth's initial intake into an OYA facility.
- 2. Staff must actively encourage all youth to participate in activities, but may not sanction a youth if the youth chooses not to participate.
- 3. Activities must be consistent with the needs and preferences of the youth.
- 4. Facilities must develop a system to gather youth comment and allow for evaluation of activities and development of new activities that interest youth.
- 5. Activities must be appropriate to the age, abilities, and special needs of the youth involved, and designed so all participants may feel a sense of accomplishment.
- 6. Activities must occur within a structured and supervised setting.
- 7. Activities must relate to the youth's individual case plan goals and include opportunities for leisure and social interaction.
- 8. Non-competitive and competitive sports must be included in the recreation program.
- 9. Quiet time leisure activities must be included in the recreation program, such as arts and crafts, and reading.
- 10. Opportunities for both indoor and outdoor activities must be included in the recreation program.
- 11. Staff must encourage interaction with the community by inviting community groups to present recreational and entertainment programs within the facility.
- 12. Staff may take youth into the community to participate in recreational activities as part of transition/camp facility programs.

C. Supervision of Youth

1. Staff must provide direct supervision of all youth physical recreational activities, with increased awareness of activities where scissors, controlled items, or dangerous tools may be used.
2. Staff who supervise youth physical activity must have completed general youth supervision training relevant to the facility in which they are working.
3. Staff must use caution when actively participating in recreational activities with youth to ensure they are demonstrating activity skills and are refraining from physical contact with youth.
4. Facility administration may allow periodic staff vs. youth activities as special events and to promote healthy morale. Staff are cautioned to avoid injury and overexertion during these activities.
5. Horseplay is prohibited. This includes rough or boisterous play, mock-wrestling, and physical pranks or teasing that is directed towards a person (e.g., spraying with a water hose; verbal jesting).

D. Reporting

Staff must record youth participation in group recreation in JJIS "attendance tracking."

E. All OYA facilities must refer to the OSAA Heat Index calculator anytime the temperature is predicted to be 80 degrees Fahrenheit or over and follow the recommended guidelines for youth activities.

1. Superintendents/camp directors must designate a staff for each shift to monitor the heat index.
2. Staff may use this link to access the OSAA Heat Index calculator and guidelines: <https://www.osaa.org/heat-index>

V. LOCAL OPERATING PROCEDURE REQUIRED: NO